

CHAPTER 5: GO ON WALKS. SEE INTRUDERS.

Teams Terrian and Cruia arrived very late at the war mage gym. Cruia was impressed with Terrian's gym, but more impressed that Rhys would allow them in, as seldom would cities show that kind of trust. Dillion would for Rhys, but Cruia was much more laid back than most cities.

Since they arrived so late, Catria and Eric didn't get to go on their walk. Everyone was quickly shown to rooms and went quickly to sleep. Well, almost everyone. Hrod had first watch. Normally war mages rotated watches during the night. There was never supposed to be any blood drawn outside of the arena, but none of the teams really trust the others. Terrian thought they could trust Cruia, and hopefully they were right to.

Hrod spent his shift walking around the outside of the building and then coming in and practicing. He fought with two smooth metal balls on chains that were about eighteen inches long. Leather loops at the ends of the

chains allowed him to hold them and swing them around to strike his opponent. He called them poi balls, as the term poi was apparently the fairy word for the weapon. At least that's what he was told by people in Alfir, and they were all part fairy.

He was spinning the balls around and practicing striking a target when Catria suddenly came in.

"Can't sleep?" he asked.

"It's been an overwhelming day," Catria explained. "I went on a soul quest, almost died, saw a unicorn, am here with team Cruia and a Phyrnian escapee, and..." She blushed and didn't finish her sentence.

"And you really want Erik to court you," Hrod finished. "I see it in your eyes."

"I can't have feelings for him," Catria countered. "We just met. It's just that..." She paced for a moment. "Maybe it's just because he helped me on my soul quest, but I... Well, he did see a unicorn, so he must be as incredible as I think."

Hrod laughed. "Do I need to encourage him? I think he should call on you." He chuckled. "You two together... Both unicorn... That could be a powerful combination."

"I'm not interested in power," Catria countered. "I just want to be able to heal people and for my father to keep his province."

"You're going to do great," Hrod assured her. "I see

why you saw unicorn.” He chuckled. “No unicorn here. I have badger.” He shrugged. “Of course I am pretty resilient due to it. I like my magic.”

“You are good,” Catria complimented. “Were you overwhelmed when you went on your soul quest?”

“Yes, and no,” Hrod answered. “Everyone is a bit overwhelmed at soul quests, but mine went pretty smoothly, and I had been practicing to become a war mage for a long time.”

Catria sat down on a mat. “Did I do the right thing?”

Hrod shrugged. “Make it the right thing.”

He was happy to talk to her until she thought she could go to sleep and left.

When Catria woke up, Hrod was not on watch. Sean was.

“Morning, Catria,” he greeted.

She looked around the gym. “Morning, Sean.”

It didn’t take long for her to see that Erik was already up and working out. She walked over to him and asked, “Have you had breakfast?”

“Not yet,” he answered. “I didn’t want to make myself too at home here, and no one on your team is up yet except you and Sean.”

Sean waved to him and then announced, “I’m going outside to check around the building.”

He quickly left, leaving Erik and Catria alone.

“Would you like me to make breakfast for you?” she asked Erik. “What do you like to eat?”

“I’m not picky,” he answered. “Honestly, I eat everything.”

“Then I’ll surprise you,” Catria responded.

“Or I can come cook with you,” Erik offered.

She smiled. “You cook?”

“Not wonderfully well,” Eric answered. “But I can cook eggs and bacon.”

They both went to the kitchen and started cooking.

Catria smiled the entire time. Something about being with Erik felt so natural.

They were making breakfast when most of the other war mages came in. Quite a few started helping make breakfast. Since there were people to do the basics, Catria went to making blueberry syrup.

When they were done cooking, everyone gathered to eat. Where it was enjoyable having everyone around, Catria wished she was able to just be with Erik. Did he feel the same way? He had said he wanted to court her, so likely he did.

After breakfast they all cleaned up and Rhys told Terrian it was time to practice. He was surprised that Cruia asked to practice with them. The war mages really had fun sparring with each other.

Catria was trying to practice with her staff and feeling

very frustrated that she really didn't know how to use it when Erik came up. "Can I help?"

She gladly accepted, so soon he was showing her some basic strikes, smashes, swings, and thrusts. At one point he stood behind her, put his hands on hers and moved her her hands the correct way.

How could she even focus when he had his arms around her like that. She was tingling all over, his touch magic.

She turned around to ask him a question, and he was right there, close enough to kiss. "Sorry," she apologized.

"No problem," he assured her. "I'm still hoping for a nice moonlight walk before lunch."

"Moonlight walk," Catria laughed. "Before lunch?"

"We are going to leave today," Erik explained, so I can't wait until tonight."

"Back to work," Rhys called over to Catria. "You need to learn to fight, and Cruia needs to leave soon, or Xena will be found here."

Unfortunately, that was true. If only Cruia could stay longer. Why couldn't Erik be on Terrian's team?

Because both teams were enjoying fighting each other, they didn't leave early, so Erik and Catria actually got there walk right after lunch.

Catria knew the woods well, so she took him out along some paths in the woods.

They talked of many things... things they enjoyed, things they didn't, hopes, dreams, values,...

Where Catria had become a war mage to help her father keep his province, Erik just liked the idea of being able to protect people.

Erik came from a large family, which he said was pretty normal in Cruia. Catria liked that. She too came from a large family and wanted one.

After finding they shared the important parts of relationships, how much they had in common, and just seeing how impressive he was, Catria couldn't help but find herself entirely falling for Erik. Was he as impressed with her?

They walked through a field of wildflowers right outside the woods around the Terrian gym. The weather was beautiful and the scent of flowers filled the air.

They stopped in the middle of the field and Erik took her in his arms. How could she think clearly?

"May I call on you next week?" he asked, looking deep into her eyes. "You are amazing."

She blushed. "So are you. I know we only met, but..."

He put his hand on her cheek. "I know. We only just met, but I think we have something special. Maybe I won't wait a week to come back up and visit."

The two stood with their hearts beating faster, and for a moment Catria thought Erik might kiss her, but he

didn't. Normally, she'd think it way too forward, as they'd just met, but he'd saved her life, and they had both seen a unicorn. That meant he had to be pure of heart, at least if the legends were true. What if they weren't. No, he was pure of heart.

The two were embraced when Erik suddenly jumped back, pulled his whip, and stood protectively in front of Catria.

"What's wrong?" Catria asked.

"In the woods," Erik whispered. "It sounds like people creeping around."

They both walked quietly to the edge of the woods and looked around. There were some people sneaking around.

"Are they Phyrnian?" Catria asked.

"They look to be," Erik answered. "We need to get back and inform Rhys. Likely they are hunting for Xena."